

Let me give you an example to explain further:

A friend of the female persuasion wanted to buy an MP3 player. She wanted something cool and easy to use... something that could hold her entire 4 GB song collection and some videos/movies, and that offered decent battery life. Now I happen to know that this damsel in distress has a really slow computer, with USB 1.1 connectors, so if I suggested an iPod, she'd be cursing me every time she wanted to transfer music to her player. I'm sure you'll agree that Apple's pushing of QuickTime as the only way to transfer music to and from your iPod is irritating.

So I suggested a Creative Zen Vision:M. It's got a nice 262K colour screen, which makes the iPod's 65K screen look pale. She bought one, and was thrilled...for exactly four days and five hours. She went to one of her socialite gatherings, where all her colleagues were showing off their new iPod Video players. Exactly 12 minutes after she walked into the party, I got a call from her. She was disappointed with me, and refused to take my calls for five days! If only she'd asked me what was a good buy to show off with, instead of asking me for an MP3 player with good video support and decent battery life—how was I to know that her biggest need was that the gadgeter...

Should Be Popular

I made up for my folly. After spending half-an-hour with her husband, listing the feature-set of the Vision:M, he was only too happy to take that *dreadful* Zen Vision:M off his wife's hands, in exchange for buying her an iPod Video. Now, he's happily pretending to be a techie at work, citing the superior features of his Vision:M, while she's been forgiven by her friends, and has happily joined the legions of the iPeople!

I learnt the hard way that most people just do not want to start trends, they'd rather follow existing ones. Only a handful few are happy to buy a device that is powerful, has great features, is easy to use *and* is good looking. They'd rather show off with something that everyone expects them to buy, or, more importantly, something that everyone else *aspires* to buy.

Of course, what's popular isn't always bad, and as the next example will show you, sometimes...

It Just Doesn't Make Sense!

When I decided I needed a new phone, not only did I know what I would buy, but I also knew what I wouldn't. I knew the functionality I needed: basically a good GPRS phone with a great camera and music capabilities. If I was to go *only* by the advertisements on TV, I would have ended up with a Sony Ericsson W800i Walkman phone. Instead, I went out and bought the Sony Ericsson K750i... The price difference, then, between the two was about Rs 5,000. There is no hardware difference between the two models, the W800i just ships with a 512 MB memory card, as opposed to 64 MB with the K750i, and the W800i has a hands-free cable that allows you to connect any pair of headphones to it. Apart from this, they are identical—and honestly, I prefer the K750i's colour and sliding lens cover.

Even today, the W800i is available for about Rs 15,000, about Rs 4,000 more than the K750i. For the difference, you can buy a 2 GB memory card *and* the W800i's hands-free connector—and if you really want, you can flash your K750i with the W800i's firmware. You'll still end up saving about Rs. 2000!

Thankfully, buyers seem to have seen this very obvious flaw in product positioning and pricing, and the K750i seems to have become the popular choice. However, I wonder how many people went out and bought the W800i, based solely on the TV ads, instead of checking specifications and reading reviews? And remember, this was not two competing brands, just two models of the same brand—no wonder people are so confused.

Another bad thing that marketing does, is cause...

Misconceptions

I can't count the number of people who think Windows Media Center PCs are the best thing since the invention of denim!

"Wow, I want one! I want to be able to pause TV and skip past ads!", seems to be the popular desire. And, sadly, a lot of people think that this cannot be done unless they buy a Media Center PC. We can thank Microsoft's big ad budgets for that!



If only my friend had asked me for a good buy to show off with instead of a good MP3 Player!

What people don't realise is that this little peripheral called a TV tuner card has been around for ages, and has allowed us to do all the same things, and more. And you don't need to go out and buy a new PC or laptop; your existing hardware will do just fine! In fact, most mid- to high-end TV tuner cards come bundled with software that will let you do a *lot* more than what Media Center can do—such as edit the videos you've saved using the bundled editing software. You still get a remote, a programming guide, the ability to "pause live TV", record while you're out, fast forward ads when watching recorded material, burn DVDs, etc.

At least we can thank Microsoft for popularising the usefulness of TV tuners! Which brings me to the end of this...

Ranting

The point is simple. Assess your needs and look around at options before you buy, and don't let things such as the popularity of a product sway your buying decision. This is especially true for personal devices, which need to be... well... personal; they should give you everything you need, and not just be eye-candy for your friends.

My friend, the iPerson I mentioned earlier, tells me that she still hasn't been able to transfer any video to her iPod—QuickTime and USB 1.1 are killing her joy. She also *moved* her music collection from her PC to the iPod, and now cannot transfer it to her laptop! She can thank Apple's paranoia of piracy for that! Needless to say, I have started avoiding her calls... thank God she doesn't read Digit! ■

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